

MEETING NOTES
Rules and Policy Subcommittee Meeting

November 16, 2022 (Rescheduled from November 6, 2022)

Via Zoom

Agenda

Attendance: Member Ruseau, Member Graham, Member McLaughlin - 3/0

Central Administration: Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent, Joan Bowen, Peter Cushing, Suzanne Galusi
Nicholas Tucci, Michael Downs, Emily Kammerer, Kirk Johnson, Andrew O'Brien, Nancy Sherman-Hudson, Shannon Demos, Chenine Peloquin, Ingrid Moncado

1. Wellness Policy (ADF) for K-8

As approved by the committee on May 16, 2022 (2022-35): The Rules and Policy Subcommittee will review The Wellness Policy (ADF) for K-8 students be sent to the Rules and Policy Subcommittee for revision and that it be revised as necessary to ensure unrestricted free play recess is available to all K-8 children daily as part of their social and emotional wellbeing. The curtailing of unrestricted free play recess shall be tracked. This information shall be returned to the School Committee twice each year and be disambiguated by school, grade, gender, race, disability, and socioeconomic status. The subcommittee shall invite at least one teacher and administrator from grades K-5 and 6-8, as well as the director of student services or her designee, to ensure their views are considered. The current policy and recommended revised policy will be returned to this committee no later than our first meeting in November of 2022.

- Superintendent - as a district we value recess and giving students the opportunity to get fresh air, socialize and physical movement. Everyone is in support of recess and having that as part of the day.
- Member Ruseau - in MA recess is not considered time in learning which puts us in a disadvantage to other states. We have recess at ES and MS levels.
- Suzanne Galusi - reviewed elementary level recess schedule and time frame.
- Michael Downs/Nick Tucci - reviewed MS level recess schedule and time frame, activities allowed.
- Chenine Peloquin - Developmental Specialist. In principle the district is supportive, but there are staff members that restrict the type of child directed activity and

indoor play which is sometimes on screen and not free play. Would recommend better staff training for indoor recess especially.

- Child directed play - is freely chosen, personally directed and intrinsically motivated.
- Member Ruseau - Referenced New Zealand School Without Rules video <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=r1Y0cuufVGI>
- Reviewed wellness policy in 3 or 4 surrounding communities and the common theme was that recess will not be taken away as discipline.
- Member McLaughlin - was Chenine asking for a deliverable for the School Committee?
 - Definition of child directed play for the district and wants to make sure it is preserved.
 - Teachers are not necessarily educated on child directed play and what that looks like.
- Suzanne Galusi - to my knowledge it is child directed across the district, maybe there is a limit to toys allowed and props or activities of a dangerous nature.
- Nancy Sherman-Hudson - they are directing their own play at the Missituk. Stations are available for them like a ball area, playground play, and this allows teachers to choose where they want to be to ensure safety.
- Ingrid Moncada - excited to see recess in the policy. Wants to see it protected as well and not used as a disciplinary action.
 - Hoping for consistent policy as to when indoor recess is called.
- Emily Kammerer - AMS teacher. Students also have the option to go to the library if they want. It is very desirable by many students. From the teacher's side, that option is sometimes used when a student is absent, students decide to use that time instead of staying after to make up work or get extra help - as an option not a requirement.
- Superintendent - recently at AMS there were students that chose to sit in a smaller group in indoor spaces. The overwhelming environment of the playground is not for all students so having that option is important for them so it would not be beneficial to implement a one size fits all definition for recess.
- Member Graham - It's been a few years since recess was normal, but can recall that indoor recess is NOT consistent across the district due to weather. A lot of students spend most of the winter indoors. At the MS level the choices are child directed. At the ES the choices are given by teachers. We need a district policy so that depending on what school you are at does not determine how much outdoor/indoor play a student receives. Having a written policy about what the expectations are district wide will be important.
- Shannon Demos - when we look at recess at the elementary level, it is child based but it's not going to look the same for every child. We do not have the ability to staff multiple areas, so we have benches and blankets for readers and try to accommodate without it being in a particular area. Some children need help engaging, but they have many options to feel comfortable and it is self-directed.

- I would not recommend a blanket statement, especially at the ES level not all children are dressed appropriately and prepared for weather outside.
Resources to cover that at the school are not always available.
- Michael Downs - Being outside is over stimulating for some children so some prefer the library, and we have a game area for them indoors. Not recommending taking library time away as an option.
- Suzanne Galusi - Temperature warrants indoor recess if it is too cold for example, 25 degrees feel.
 - Described logical consequences and how it may work and look like at the ES
- Member McLaughlin - respectfully disagrees that logical consequences may not make sense for children with disabilities.
 - Would like to see extra clothing available at every building
- Chenine Peloquin - Liveinthebalance.org free resource
- Nancy Sherman-Hudson - when a child does need a consequence, we use a 'time to reflect' sheet so that we can track a child's behavior. They shadow the teacher while they get outside, and it is not meant as public shaming. Also, students that see challenging behavior from other students are expecting to see a consequence.
- Andy O'Brien - a priority of recess for all adults and children is to keep it safe and self-directed play. If we identify unsafe behavior, we do administer logical consequences such as walking with the student to discuss the behavior, different choices, and reasoning. Cautioned against micromanaging recess in the future as a result of new implementation. Advocating that the school has the responsibility for taking steps to ensure safety for all students is a priority as well.
- Member Ruseau - This is not meant to micromanage going forward, wants the goal to be that there is an overall guideline across the district.
- Member McLaughlin - We are all collectively responsible as a community to create this for our schools. Is there data on who is implementing regularly or students who require these actions and have it be shared.
- Member Graham - wanted to be clear we are not looking to micromanage, and the criticism is for the School Committee that we do not have a clear policy for the district. Hoping to help administrators have a more clear guideline. It's long overdue.
- Suzanne Galusi - reiterating that it's hard to make a blanket statement about consequences but agrees there can be flexibility with it. If parents are dissatisfied about recess, they should be reaching out to teachers and principals first before SC and if it's not addressed that's another story, but it should be handled at the school level.
- Member Ruseau - agrees if SC is contacted they should be encouraging parents to reach out to school first and acknowledges SC is only getting a small slice of the big picture.
- Superintendent - important to honor the students that choose quieter choices besides physical activity.
- Member Ruseau
 - Just a more broad consistent districtwide guideline/policy.
 - The definition of recess and what is NOT recess

- That it will not be taken away as discipline.
 - Recognizing that some teachers are not educated on recess, alternatives for discipline and what is child directed.
- Member McLaughlin
 - Love the idea of PD on the topic
- Member Ruseau - will schedule another subcommittee meeting on this topic in the near future and draft language for the wellness policy

Motion to adjourn by Member McLaughlin, 2nd by Member Graham - 3/0

MEETING ADJOURNED: 5:22 PM